

The Cleanse

THE WORLD WAS GOING GA-GA OVER THE POSSIBILITIES OF A METAVERSE thanks to Facebook renaming itself (Alphabet style) for the sake of stock markets, or as some believe, to distract from the bad press from exposés. At least a couple of hours were spent debating the benefits and pitfalls of living in the metaverse, with some buying the dream that Facebook's rather cringy keynote laid out, and others reminding us about how we're all likely to become useless fat humans like the ones that are depicted in the animated movie WALL-E.

The end result is probably going to be somewhere in the middle of those two extremes, but it's certainly not going to get there without loads of stress and pain.

For starters, it might be too soon for humans to give up actual physical social interactions. Whether at work or with friends, there is much more to the experience than what is purely visible through our eyes. All of the innovations being done in tech are targeting experiences delivered via our eyes. Everything is visual, whether it's AR, XR, or VR, the race is to get to lifelike visuals, and we're about as far along as what we can see on our HD screens around us. We're still a long way off from a full dive visual experience – an artificial experience that's indistinguishable from real life. And remember, I'm only talking about visuals right now. A true full dive experience would require tech that we are nowhere close to inventing yet!

Audio might be easier to do because we have been attempting to do it for a lot longer in human history. However, with the focus being visual, many VR sets relegate audio to what's already around for games and the likes and don't really attempt to create lifelike aural experiences. For starters, something pressing down on your ears, or worse, sticking into your ears is not a lifelike experience. Sitting around in real life we can hear everything around us, but more importantly, our ears are able to feel as well. We don't just hear the breeze on a beach, we feel it too!

What's going to be the hardest thing to add in the VR world is movement. It's already good for little body movements like ducking, leaning, even jumping, but if you want to be able to run, tumble and jump across distances or anything like that, it's impossible. Instead,

you're given weird controllers to move with your thumbs to move about, which is fine for games and the like but ruins the immersion of the experience. Given that anything related to movement requires expensive equipment and large spaces, don't expect to see one in your home anytime soon.

Direct brain interfaces might be a solution there because it might be easier to fool your brain into believing it's moving than actually allow you to move about. That's still a long way off though, and it's going to take ages of testing and innovations before it's even remotely usable for the general population.

While we all want to go deeper into the metaverse for novel experiences, this column is actually going to try to get you to try another novel experience. A cleanse!

I'm actually going to be taking a month's break from all the things I use a lot in my limited free time. I'm not swearing off tech, just the more addictive aspects of it. The ones I tend to end up spending an hour on without realising it. For me, the list is short, YouTube, Facebook, WhatsApp groups, and Twitter, listed in order of time spent on each.

The line of work I am in prevents me from doing a technology cleanse, but I would highly recommend that for anyone who wants to try it. Don't even do it for a month if that feels like it's too much. Start with a day, work up to a week. Even that will force you to reprioritise some things and discover some new interests and hobbies.

I'll probably end up replacing my YouTube and Facebook time with reading more emails and browsing through more websites for research, but that's because my work demands it. Whatever personal time I can spare will obviously be added on as family time.

If you do take up the challenge to attempt a cleanse, make sure to write in and tell me how it goes. We'll include the letters in the Inbox section, which might even win one of you the letter of the month. I'll be back next month to tell you how it went... Wish me luck! 



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